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Against the Odds

Matriliny, land and gender in the Shire Highlands of Malawi

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Abstract ■ The people of the Shire Highlands in southern Malawi (with origins in Nyanja, Mang'anja, Yao, and Lomwe-speaking groups) practise a form of matriliney, including matrilineal descent and inheritance and uxori-local marriage, that has proven remarkably resilient in the face of direct and indirect challenges. These include misperceptions and prejudices about matriliney by Christian missions and European travellers; the promotion of a patriarchal nuclear family by Christian and Islamic missions, by government policies, and by estate tenancy; the attack on matriliney by the agricultural development policies of the 1940s and 1950s; and the privileging of men in extension of agricultural and other services by colonial and post-colonial governments. Today, the continued predominance of matriliney in village life provides considerable range for women's authority, especially with respect to land inheritance, and continues to provide the necessary matrix within which 'household' or elementary family based on marriage operates.

Keywords ■ colonial history ■ gender ■ land ■ Malawi ■ matriliney

'The position of the woman with the Manganja was in no way inferior to that of the man. . . . the women were the rightful owners of the village.' (Henry Rowley); 'the fair sex have their own way a great deal' (Horace Waller, Magomero mission, 1861–2) (cited in Mandala, 1990: 25)

. . . some of the evils of the matrilineal system might be overcome, if individual ownership of land takes the place of the present semi-communal system. (Richard Kettlewell, Senior Agricultural Officer, Nyasaland, 1947)

In 1986, I made the rounds of courtesy calls to the chiefs or village headmen (*amfumu*) of the villages selected for my research in Zomba district in the Shire Highlands. In two of the nine, I found women holding the position of *mfumu*. At one of these, I was met by the female chief and taken to a compound where I was seated on the sole chair and formally greeted by the chief and a group of women. The few men present sat at the side of the gathering and did not speak at all during the formal proceedings of explaining my presence and being granted permission to conduct research in the village. Afterwards, I addressed one of the men, who turned out to be the

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husband of the chief, and he informed me that they had not spoken since they were 'just sons-in-law' (*akamwini basi*) in the village. This incident forcibly registered itself on my memory since it contrasted so completely with my earlier experience in Botswana, where it had always been women who sat silently on the edges of formal gatherings. As I got to know the villages and their inhabitants, I found that all followed matrilineal principles of descent (children belong to their mother's matrilineage), the vast majority lived uxorilocally (husbands coming to live in their wives' village), most of the land passed to female heirs, and just like Rowley over a hundred years ago, I was told that women were 'owners' and 'builders' of a village.¹

While being very much part of a national state and an international political economy, people's day-to-day lives in rural Malawian villages take place largely, though not exclusively, among kin and neighbours. In the area of research, villages are organized into clusters of compounds made up of the houses of mainly matrilineal relatives. Groups of sisters live with their husbands and children, cheek by jowl with the descendants of their mothers' sisters. Most adult brothers live elsewhere – in their wives' villages or, if employed, in towns, but a few live in their own village if they married the daughters of neighbours or cousins (increasingly rare), and a very small number have been given land that belongs to their own matrilineage.² In the many domains of life governed by kinship, women exercise authority comparable to men's. Beyond these domains, male authority is the norm and women are largely marginalized. Although a few chiefs are women, most are men and, in most cases, female chiefs are seen as 'holding the place' for a brother, son or grandson. The upper ranks of chiefs (the 'group headmen' and the 'Traditional Authorities' or territorial chiefs) are all male. Similarly, the structure of authority in government, civil service, Christian and Muslim religious hierarchies, public sectors (education, health), and private corporations is overwhelmingly male. The numbers of women in top positions in these hierarchies have increased somewhat only very recently. Within villages, the arms of these 'outside' authorities bring with them the assumptions and reinforcement of male authority. Hence, agricultural services, including farmers' credit clubs, have been overwhelmingly directed to men; political party representatives are mostly men, as are those of business or similar organizations (such as the tobacco association).

What might account for the difference, even disjuncture, between the latter, with their privileging of male authority, and the matrilineal kinship organization that provides considerable scope for women to exercise authority? Discussions of the 'problems of matriliney' tend to have neglected their historical context (see 'Introduction'). One cannot over-stress the fact that matrilineal groups have been and continue to be a minority in a sea of patriliney and patriarchy. Most groups in all the African regions where matriliney is found follow patrilineal, dual or cognatic descent, and all the

major influences entering over the past 200 years and more have been from strongly patrilineal or bilateral, and patriarchal groups. These include, for the Malawi case described here, Islamic groups, Christian missions, British colonial over-rule and plantation agriculture. The ideas and practices brought by all the former are reinforced in this 'global' world because major players (America, Europe, Russia, Japan, China . . .) all favour patrilineal or bilateral modes of organization.

The tension between matrilineal and patriarchal ideologies turns, in present-day Malawi, on the play between matrilineality and gender relations. The former gives considerable scope for women's independent action, the latter tend to privilege men. Matrilineal succession and inheritance, especially of land (in a very densely populated region), along with uxorilocal residence, provide women with considerable scope for authority and independent action by comparison with men, both as brothers and husbands. But this is not a situation of gender equality. Gender ideologies and relations are closely related to but not determined by matrilineality. Neither can be understood without placing them in the context of historical processes.

In the next few sections, I give very brief accounts of indirect and direct challenges to matriliney by the promotion of the patriarchal nuclear family by missionaries, the preference for a male-headed family by estate owners seeking to control the numbers of tenants resident on their land, the assumption of a male-headed household in government policies, the direct attack on matriliney in the agricultural policies and programmes of the 1940s and 1950s, and the colonial and post-independent governments' habit of directing agricultural extension and services to men rather than women. I then turn to the contemporary situation in the southern Shire Highlands where the overwhelmingly matrilineal organization thrives against all the odds of past and present attacks.

For this article, I take the relations around land as the main thread in addressing the question of matriliney's resilience 'against the odds'. Land is the source of livelihood and wealth for the vast majority of Malawians, as it has been over the known history of the country's peoples, with the exception of the period of slavery. The vast amounts of land in the Shire Highlands acquired by Europeans around the turn of the century are testimony to the recognition of the land's potential. The colonial history of Nyasaland (Malawi) was dominated by issues of control over land between European settlers and Africans, and by the resulting need for the colonial government to attend to 'the question of labour', especially that of tenancy on the estates. Under the Nyasaland Protectorate, as in independent Malawi, the national income and food supplies have come overwhelmingly from the land and its products. The key export crops have been tobacco, tea, coffee, and a range of others, and the pre-eminent food crop is maize, along with other cereals, root crops and legumes. While income from migrant labour

to South Africa and the Rhodesias has been an important source for many families at certain periods, that from the land, in the form of food and cash crops, has been the basis of life for the majority of Malawi's people. To have access and rights to land has been and continues to be a central aim for most people. That land (under customary tenure) devolves through women to women in the area of the Shire Highlands is therefore of singular importance to women and their families.

Missionaries and Matriliney

The UMCA (Universities' Mission to Central Africa) was the first to arrive in the region after David Livingstone had described it as ripe for the entry of 'Christianity and Commerce'. In his observations of Mang'anja life around Magomero mission, Henry Rowley was most intrigued by the relations between men and women:

I was much struck with the regard which the men had for the women, whose position seemed to be in no way inferior to that of the men; and the men, not the women, carried the heavy burdens of rice . . . for sale. Indeed, it was at times amusing to see the deference which the men sometimes paid the women by going to them and asking their opinion before concluding a bargain. (1867: 26)

His being 'struck' by the 'regard' men had for women and his 'amusement' at the 'deference' men showed women by asking their opinion tell us more about his own assumptions – as Victorian churchman – about appropriate male–female interactions, of course, than about Mang'anja ways.

The missionaries appeared not to connect the remarkably egalitarian relations between men and women to matrilineality. As the Mission gathered in freed slaves, its head, Bishop Mackenzie, became concerned about the sexual improprieties among the men and women who quietly refused to accept the 'segregation of the sexes' into two different areas of the compound. Having described to them 'the rules of Christian marriage', he was pleased to find a young man coming to him to ask for a particular woman in marriage, an example that very quickly proliferated when the man not only received a wife but also a plot of land. As Landeg White points out, not only did this bestowal of land mean, in local custom, that the Bishop had acted as a chief but it 'vested . . . important rights and powers . . . in men [as husbands], to whom the women became subordinate' (1987: 37). In light of Elias Mandala's exposition of the extensive political authority deployed by Mang'anja women as sisters of chiefs and lineage heads, and their virtual monopoly of key religious roles (1990: 23), this was a radical change.

The pattern did not take hold, however, at least among the bulk of the

population. By the first decades of the 20th century, the monogamous, 'male-headed' nuclear family had become a mark of the tiny elite of mission-educated Africans. But, even among these, matrilineal descent and inheritance seem not to have been displaced. Even where a couple and their children lived away from the wife's home (usually in mission stations and, later, in towns where the man was in colonial and private employment), children were seen to belong to their mother's matrilineal group, and matrilin for each spouse remained the main pivot of social relationships.

Estates, Tenants and Family Organization³

Another major influence on matrilineal organization came from the tenancy system put in place by the estates. The Magomero mission failed within two years, victim of famine, and its own naive meddling in the inter-African wars fuelled by slavery. After the departure of the missionaries and deaths of several of them, famine and war took hold of the region. But in the next decade, new missions arrived to start afresh in the Highlands and in areas further north. Traders and aspiring planters also arrived. By 1910, nearly 1 million acres of land in the Shire Highlands had been obtained by Europeans at very low cost from Yao and Nyanja chiefs. One of the largest purchasers of land was Alexander Low Bruce, a son-in-law of David Livingstone, who acquired the largest single block of land in the country, some 160,000 acres, spread across the areas later known as Chiradzulu and Zomba districts. The Bruce estate included the site of the Magomero mission and the villages where I have been doing research.

Once land was obtained, the new owners were faced with the problem of acquiring sufficient labour to work it. At first, forcible recruitment by the colonial government, and the need to earn money for the new taxes were the major vehicles (Vail, 1983: 44), combined with attempts to recruit seasonal labourers from the north of the country and from Portuguese East Africa. But these proved insufficient to the rising demand for workers from the estates and from government itself, and the estate owners found a more effective answer in resident tenancy, a system that was a constant source of dissatisfaction and dispute throughout the entire colonial period (as witnessed in the reports of district commissioners and the many land and tenancy commissions set up by the administration). Some of the people resident on land appropriated for the estates moved off onto the surrounding 'crown' land (subsequently, 'native trust' and finally 'customary' land). Many stayed and were joined during the first 30 years of the 20th century by thousands of Lomwe-speaking immigrants from Portuguese East Africa (Pike and Rimmington, 1965; Vail, 1983; White, 1987).

The estate owners were interested in attracting able-bodied men as workers and conceived of the men as 'heads' of the tenant families from

whom they obtained the obligated labour rent. In all the ordinances passed by the colonial administration concerning tenancy, the reference was to 'the tenant . . . he'. In the early years, the government tried unsuccessfully to oblige estate owners to set aside land for cultivation for tenants' families, and to allow tenants the option of paying their 'rent' in money rather than labour. The government was never able to enforce these ordinances because the estates were far more interested in the labour of tenants than in cash. Estates consistently assumed a male-headed household for work obligations, land allocations and housing (Palmer, 1984: 217; White, 1987: 100). In practice, the persisting matrilineal organization of the resident population posed a problem for the estates.

The growth in population, first in immigrant flows then in natural growth, combined with the economic depression of the early 1930s to reduce the demand for labour. Estate owners began to complain that they had too many resident labourers. This is when the first overt complaints about matriliney surfaced. It was particularly the practice of uxorilocal marriage that came under fire because, as daughters matured and married, so their new husbands joined them in their homes. This meant a steady increase in the number of young men coming on to the estates. Owners called for a ban on this practice, arguing that they should have the right to forbid newcomers coming to live on their land.⁴ They argued that only young children should be allowed to remain on the estates and that, as young people matured and married, they should leave and find their own place. African resistance to this upheaval in their customary ways and reluctance of the government to support such a radical change meant that estate owners were unable to put their suggestions into practice. The subsequent boom in tobacco prices during the 1940s and the break-up of the huge estates into smaller ones during the same period diffused the perceived problem since the demand for labour rose once again.

Just as the estate owners (and colonial authorities) assumed and promoted men as the natural holders of land and heads of households, so they assigned authority to men as foremen for supervision of labourers. The men, called '*capitaos*' (a term from Portuguese East Africa), not only regulated labour but also were expected to ensure broader oversight and order on the estates, sometimes coming into conflict with local chiefs. In my area of research, oral histories indicate that the senior ranks of the *capitaos* were often allocated large areas of land by the estate managers on which they settled their matrilineal relatives. For example, Samuel (pseudonym) was appointed *capitao* sometime in the late 1930s or early 1940s. The land he was allocated is now held by his sisters' descendants. These claim Samuel was a 'chief' (*mfumu*), whereas the current village chief, who is the third incumbent with the village name, says Samuel was merely a helper of the then chief, who had been recognized by the estate but who, the present chief says, was the descendant of chiefs from Portuguese East Africa.

Like all the families whose histories I collected, the matrilineal descendants of Samuel all describe their coming as a brother–sister group. Samuel's remaining sister, now close to 90, described her arrival with her brother and the arrival of other matrilineal relatives. Talking of her own children, she described herself as 'making an *mbumba*' (minimal matrilineage). In one of our conversations, one daughter, helping her mother with the names of the various descendants of the mother's sisters living in neighbouring areas, exclaimed: 'Truly, mother has peopled the village!' The land received by Samuel from the estate was distributed among his matrikin and is today occupied by his sisters' daughters, while all the male descendants have left. Since the number of descendants is more than the land can absorb, many of the female descendants have left, and more in the youngest generation will eventually have to do so.

Although, then, the land was given to Samuel, seen by the estates as 'the household head', it passed into the matrilineal line immediately. Moreover, in the oral histories provided by different members of this large family, neither the founding sisters' husbands nor the wife of Samuel were mentioned. Only when I asked about the latter did Samuel's elderly sister say that after the death of her brother, they (the matrikin) had 'chased away' the wife and children because they feared they would take over the 'chiefship'.⁵

The family histories I collected all describe the movements of families in terms of a brother–sister (uterine) core, and all demonstrate the reversion to matrilineal inheritance of land allocated to men by the estates. This is contrary to what Landeg White supposed was the outcome of estate practices in the 1930s. He described how tobacco production on estates led to the expectation that 'certain property rights were vested in the men' and that a man's 'tobacco land, . . . barn and . . . hoes would be inherited directly by his sons' (1987: 178). At least for Zomba villages this 'turning point' in inheritance towards the patrilineal did not take place. The main effect of the estates' allocation of land was not to cause a shift from matrilineal and uxorilocal practices but to enable certain families to benefit from land allocations (and the wages and contacts to make the land productive). Since the original allocations (between the 1930s and late 1940s, mostly), the growth in population has restricted advantage to only a few branches of the recipient's matrilineal group. Particular matrilineal groups and individuals have benefited, but no significant change in matrilineal ideologies or practices has occurred.

Colonial Government Policies and Matriliney⁶

Like the estates, the colonial administration tended to assume a nuclear family of man, wife and children in its procedures for taxation, regulating

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employment, or, in later years, in providing extension 'messages' and services to farmers. Since this assumption did not fit much of what were people's actual production and consumption practices, problems often arose, as, for example, during the famine in parts of the Shire Highlands in 1949 (Vaughan, 1987). Most of the problems caused in this way were those of inappropriate assumptions rather than any animus against matriliney. This was to change.

The administration did not show any great interest in the prevailing matrilineal organization of the Shire Highlands until the 1940s when an ambitious programme of agricultural development took form. During the 1930s, agricultural policy towards African agriculture remained fairly cautious. Most official interest in agriculture focused on recovering from the depression and, as the decade wore on, developing solutions to what was considered to be the mounting threat of soil erosion. After the end of the Second World War and the return of demobilized officers, the entire tenor of the administration became far more ambitious and confident about the need for and possibility of rapid change towards modernity. In agriculture, a key figure was Richard Kettlewell who returned to be made senior Agricultural Officer in Lilongwe, later becoming the Director of Agriculture, and, as the country moved towards independence, the Minister for Natural Resources.

The 1940s in Nyasaland were marked by a new theme in government (and settler) circles about a looming crisis in agricultural production of food, which tied together several threads in opinions about African agricultural production. There was a long-standing concern about a growing population putting pressure on the land, increasing degradation and declining agricultural yields. Additionally, the government had the responsibility of finding land for 'surplus' tenants evicted by estates. The shortages in national supplies of food for sale were interpreted as due to shortfalls in production which, in turn, were attributed to the shortcomings in the prevailing methods of farming. The culmination of these processes and interpretations, in the context of a post-war ebullience about the promise of technology in the cause of economic development, was the formulation of an ambitious programme for rapid modernization of agriculture.

In response to a despatch from the Colonial Secretary in 1947 on the need for a revolution in agricultural productivity in order to raise the standard of living for Africans, a series of memoranda and meetings among the agricultural and other officers produced the new policy direction.⁷ Senior staff in agriculture, especially Kettlewell and E. Lawrence, described the changes they considered necessary in explicit parallel with the 'agricultural revolution' in England: a large-scale removal of Africans from crowded areas in the southern province, some to be resettled on estates as labourers living in 'model villages' with only a quarter of an acre for a vegetable

garden, some to be absorbed into new 'secondary industries', while the better African agriculturalists were to be settled on 'land owned by themselves' which they would farm under supervision in a modern way. Kettlewell emphasized the need for reform in land tenure, proposing that 'some of the evils of the matrilineal system will be overcome, if individual ownership of land takes the place of the present semi-communal system'. This emphasis on matriliney as an obstacle to agricultural progress is one that is particular to Kettlewell and one he never relinquished. I do not know the full explanation for his particular animus against matriliney but I want to suggest, briefly, that the papers from the Nutrition Survey of 1938 provide clues to the bases for Kettlewell's later concerted attacks on matriliney.

Margaret Read wrote a chapter on the sociology and history of the three sample villages of the Nutrition Survey which has been included in full in the recently published survey papers (Berry and Petty, 1992). A key dimension of contrast, according to Read, was the degree to which villages were matrilineal or patrilineal (see the article by Brantley, this issue, for a description of the villages). Read remarks on the deleterious effects of male labour emigration on food production (a concern of the colonial administration) but says patrilineal groups fared better because the in-marrying wife 'is a stranger in the village, [and] she generally maintains the joint garden of herself and her husband fearing to incur the wrath of her parents-in-law if she did otherwise'. In matrilineal areas, by contrast, 'she may hoe a much smaller garden, or even none at all, depending for her food supply on her mother, who has no larger garden for that purpose' (1992: 47). Exactly the same claim is made in the report's agricultural chapter by Kettlewell as an explanation of the fact that in the patrilineal hill village 'the grass widows [women with absent husbands] cultivate nearly three-quarters of an acre more than in the foothill village'. He states that in matrilineal, uxori-local groups, a young woman whose husband migrates for work depends on her parents' garden whereas 'in patrilocal societies . . . the wife . . . maintains as far as possible the extent of their original garden, largely by brewing beer for work by hoeing parties' (1992: 71).

This explanation for the difference in gardens maintained by 'grass widows' becomes highly questionable when one examines the quantitative data he provided on the villages. These show that the hill village had more productive resources than the foothill village – a fair proportion of *dimba* (the highly fertile streambed gardens), twice the ratio of land available to land used, and more livestock. Moreover, in the foothill and lakeshore villages more men were employed in weaving mats and baskets for sale, an occupation that demands considerable input of work, so decreasing the amount of male labour put into crop production. It seems to me, then, that the data provided by the survey itself would lead one to attribute the higher food supply in the hill village as compared with the foothill and lakeshore villages to differences in resources, income strategies and division of labour

rather than to the fact that the former was patrilineal (patrilocal) and the latter matrilineal (matrilocal).

As Cynthia Brantley shows in her article (this issue), Read's interpretations were overly influenced by an Ngoni-centric view. In turn, it appears that Kettlewell either found Read's line of interpretation convincing or used Read's ideas to support an interpretation he had already formed. Whatever the case, by the mid-1940s, his opinions on the appropriate direction for agricultural policy were buttressed, in part, by contrasting the matrilineal, uxorilocal organization in Nyasaland unfavourably with the social basis of agricultural revolution in 17th- and 18th-century England. Invoking the enclosure movements in England and the associated improvements in agricultural methods, he hoped that 'something akin to the Yeoman Farmer might be evolved out of the few progressive native agriculturalists' who, he felt, were breaking out from the matrilineal system, and 'seeking a settled life on the land'. Encouraging the formation of a class of yeomen farmers would require the establishment of cooperatives to funnel credit for implements, fertilizer, and services to the farmers. Such a system would produce 'small occupiers' enjoying the 'benefits of capital' although Kettlewell also accepted the need for 'bold experiments' in collective farming in some parts of the country (MNA NS 1/15/4).

The more radical parts of the plan were never put into practice. The governor of the Protectorate accepted the need for increased compulsion in promoting proper agricultural methods but declared the 'partial rural depopulation' advocated by the agriculture officers to be 'impracticable' in light of the shortage of land and existing pressure of population. While administrative officers, especially in the governor's office, debated the considerable administrative problems entailed in the need to resettle people on newly acquired land, the visionaries in the department of agriculture, like Kettlewell, saw a great opportunity for reorganizing agricultural practice in the new areas. The settlement schemes appeared to provide a *tabula rasa* for establishing an entirely new type of agriculture. Each selected 'master farmer' (the label finally chosen) was to receive 12, later reduced to 8, acres for house, outbuildings, garden, orchard, woodland, arable land and, eventually, mixed stock. This unit was considered within the reach of a 'hardworking family', taken to be a household of man, wife and children. As indicated above, this did not reflect the lived reality of the villages. Moreover, the consistent assumption that 'the farmer' was a man and women were 'farmers' wives' was completely at odds with the reality then and now. That women actually worked in the fields was recognized but this observed fact was interpreted as women's being, at best, helpers of their husbands, the farmers.

During the 1950s, the programmes of resettlement and 'reorganization' of land for modern farming were initiated, relying on 'master farmers' as the spearhead of progressive change. However, by mid-1960, all

had 'collapsed' with farmers reverting to their prior methods of cultivation (McLoughlin, 1967). The most obvious cause of the debacle was the mounting political unrest resulting from popular dislike of the Federation with the Rhodesias and the independence movement then gaining strength. The 'emergency' declared in 1959 put all development work on hold. But it is also clear that the blueprint of the yeoman farmer on *his* farm, practising rotation of single-cropped fields, was so far removed from local practices that the schemes would have failed even without the political emergency.

McLoughlin (1967) points to two particular issues. First, the combined conditions of highly labour-intensive methods, the requirement that up to a third of land be in fallow and a serious underestimate of the time needed for the 'improved' methods to produce increases in yield, all led to *reductions* in the average family's food supply. Second, and significantly, McLoughlin reports collecting 'hearsay' evidence that the schemes failed because of 'objections by women' to official attempts to give land title to their husbands, claiming that the land was *theirs*, and belonged neither to the husbands nor to the chiefs. Moreover, it appears that most men accepted the validity of this view since McLoughlin says that although the government wished to issue title to male farmers, there was 'a dearth of men demanding such titles'.

One of the villages where I do research is situated in a part of the former Bruce estate which was selected as a site for one of the resettlement schemes of the 1950s. A few of the original settlers are still living and have told me of their dislike of the forced rotations and single-stand cultivation, and their resistance to them. The then and still current headman was put in jail twice for failing to follow the recommended practices, and others were fined. People's objections were based on the incompatibilities between the prevailing production and consumption practices and those required under the scheme, between conflicting ideals of settlement, and between matrilineal and uxori-local principles in face of a patriarchal, nucleated model. Whatever the rationales for dislike, the schemes failed as designed. Today, the villages in the area of the former scheme differ little from those surrounding them on 'unorganized' lands. Cultivation is based on the practices of complex inter-cropping and crop sequencing typical of this part of southern Malawi. Only a few fields reveal some of the straight boundary lines drawn in the 1950s; most have disappeared over time, as field boundaries are redrawn depending on changes in crops grown, climatic and ecological change, and inheritance. The only straight lines remaining in the area are those of the main dirt roads and of the abutting fields.

After the debacle of the ambitious but misconceived agricultural resettlement schemes, villagers looked to their newly independent government under Dr Banda, the 'saviour' of the country from the hated Federation, for a new era. Immediately after independence, there appeared to be the

promised turn away from the colonial policies. Some controls were dismantled – the hated ‘agricultural rules’ on land-use methods (Kalinga, 1993: 385) and the production of tobacco was allowed to expand. A pro-farmer, ‘populist’ flavour to the first development plan (Thomas, 1975: 38) appeared to augur a new era for ‘African cultivators’. Within a short period, however, Dr Banda’s government returned to regulation, an even more punitive regime of controls than that of the last decade of colonial rule, the reintroduction of a strategy focusing on ‘master’ farmers, now renamed *achikumbé* (Kalinga, 1993; Thomas, 1975), and an expansion in the formation of estates and their benefits at the cost of smallholder farmers on customary land. The growth in national production up through the 1970s was ‘achieved by directing the investment resources of the commercial banks and . . . ADMARC [the marketing parastatal] . . . into private tobacco estates’ (Kydd, 1988: 31; cf. Kydd and Christiansen, 1982: 368). The result was a ‘reduction in the real rate of return to labour in the peasant sector’ and ‘a transfer of labour from peasant agriculture to estates, despite a continuous decline in the real wage paid to estate labour’ (Kydd and Christiansen, 1982: 366), which was, in turn, a product of the government’s minimum wage policy (Thomas, 1975: 44). The ban imposed by Dr Banda in 1974 on labour migration to South Africa, ostensibly because of a major air crash, removed one of the few paying options to male labourers and forced even more into the estates (Kydd and Christiansen, 1982: 358).

It was not until the financial crisis of 1979–80, which weakened the bargaining position of the government, that aid donors put pressure on Banda to shift the emphasis away from estate production. At this time, too, there was the more general move towards a discourse of ‘liberalization’ as part of the programmes of ‘structural adjustment’ being promoted as the solution to the economic problems in Africa and other poor countries, and political changes that resulted in the fall of Dr Banda and a new ‘multi-party’ government. Positive outcomes seen in the early 1990s have been a moratorium placed on further alienation of customary land to leasehold estates, and the lifting of an embargo on smallholders being able to grow burley tobacco. Less positive for smallholders have been the removal of fertilizer subsidies, scaling back in marketing board centres for purchase and sale of maize, and the rise in consumer prices for maize (particularly in urban markets but also in rural ones). These issues cannot be discussed here but it should be noted that the continued direction of agricultural and other services to men as the key farmers redounded to the disadvantage of many women.

Kinship Organization Today

Whenever people in the study villages⁸ differentiate themselves from Malawians from further north and south, they identify the different ways of

reckoning descent and contracting marriage. They say that they follow their mother's line whereas other groups (such as the Tumbuka from northern Malawi) follow their father's line, and husbands come to live in their wives' villages. The term 'breast' (*bele*) is used to refer to matrikin – persons descended from a named female ancestor. The term may refer to a core group descended from a common grandmother (i.e. a four-generation line), or wider sets of matrikin, such as a group of descendants of the siblings of a great-grandmother or great-great-grandmother (i.e. several collateral lines of five or more generations). One form of differentiation within the matrilineage is to recognize one line as the 'big breast', the line descended from the senior sister, as contrasted with 'small breasts', the junior lines. This has most significance for chiefly families where disputes over succession invariably turn on claims of seniority.

There is less unanimity over other terms for kin groups. The most commonly agreed is *mtundu* for the widest group of matrikin, though since specific descent usually cannot be traced, the term most resembles 'clan'. In some cases, it is used even more broadly to mean something like 'tribe' or 'people', such as the Lomwe, Nyanja or Yao. Literally, it means 'kind'. Some people say that other terms for a 'breast' or matrilineage include *leman*a or *khomo*. Others disagree, saying that *leman*a means any 'group' and not just matrikin, and that *khomo*, literally 'doorway', refers to compound, hence a residential group rather than a kin group.

The term most commonly used to describe matrikin, apart from 'breast', is *mbumba*, which is the group of sisters and their children under the 'guardianship' of an elder brother. The conventional English translation of this term is sorority group. The *mbumba* may also be seen as the smallest matrilineal group or 'the effective minimal lineage' in the words of J.C. Mitchell (1951: 316), using Fortes's phrase to describe the Yao kinship system. But the term, like 'breast', can refer to a group of matrikin over a narrower or wider scale. People in my study area tend to describe the *mbumba* as the group for which a mother's brother or brother will be responsible for *chinkhoswe*. This is the complex of responsibilities incumbent on a (mother's) brother, such as marriage surety and counsellor, representative in disputes, caregiver in times of difficulties; the 'guardian', as *nkhoswe* is usually translated in English, mediates between the woman (and her children) and the rest of the world – husband and affines, neighbours, others. Although each group of sisters normally has a particular brother or mother's brother who performs the main role of guardianship, the scale of kin within which a male matrilineal relative does so will vary. Hence, a young man described to me how, as he got older, he would be called on to perform *chinkhoswe* for his own sisters and their children, but also, if needed, for the daughters of his mother's sisters, and even for the daughters of his mother's mother's sister's daughters, some of whom lived nearby.

Although general descriptions of guardianship invariably assume the

nhkoswe to be male, conventionally the brother or mother's brother, in practice in the study villages women also regularly perform *chinkhoswe*. The marriage negotiations for one young man were conducted by several 'guardians' – his mother's elder brother and his mother's younger sister. In a case of dispute over property, one of the guardians was to be the mother of the widow, another to be her mother's brother. In these and other cases, the performance of the duties by the women was not described as in any way replacing a man but as parallel to those of the male guardian(s). Whether this is a modern phenomenon, I am not in a position, at present, to say. Similarly, I cited above a woman who described her large progeny as evidence of her 'building an *mbumba*', while another woman described herself as 'building a village'. Quoting a personal communication from Max Marwick (who had studied the Chewa of eastern Zambia), Mitchell said that a woman could not 'own' an *mbumba*, only a man could do so (1951: 317). Today, women in the Shire Highlands still refer to their male matrikin as the 'owners' (properly, the guardians) of the *mbumba*, but they see themselves as creating the matrilineage, and they perform *chinkhoswe* along with their brothers.

Children belong without question to their mother's group, and names and property follow the matriline (i.e. descent, succession and inheritance are matrilineal). Since the great majority of marriages in the area are also uxorilocal, whereby the husband lives in his wife's village and, usually, family compound, a child is brought up surrounded by his/her mother's matrikin.⁹ Children of a group of sisters refer to each other and think of each other as siblings. Throughout life, matrikin provide the surest support and the closest ties to a person, though they are also the main rivals in competition over land, wealth and status and, therefore, the main subjects of accusations of witchcraft.

At the same time, a child is seen as connected importantly to its father. Although individual marriages often do not last more than a few years, a young woman's first child is ideally the product of a marriage. First marriage is usually the only one celebrated. Fathers are considered to contribute physically to the growth of the baby in the mother's womb and, equally important, to be crucially responsible for the health and well-being of the unborn baby and its mother. Hidden adultery and other moral infringements can transfer harm to the child, producing *tsempho*, which has to be treated with special rituals. After the birth of the child, the father's behaviour continues to have ritual effect for the baby and, of course, his contributions of work and income are essential to the proper upbringing of the child. The husband is referred to as *mkamwini*, son-in-law, and is expected to impregnate his wife, so 'peopling' his wife's matrilineage, to care for his wife and children, as well as to contribute materially to his wife's close kin, especially mother. A 'good' husband divides the money he earns with his wife whereas a 'bad' one uses most for his own purposes, forcing

his wife to either beg her husband for help or fend for herself. Both spouses usually keep control over whatever monies they earn (from selling crops, beer, or doing casual work), but a good marriage is marked by the reciprocal knowledge and sharing of each other's income and by a minimum of conflict over the resources directed by each spouse to his/her respective matrilineal group.

Children take the name of the *mfunda* (matriclan) of their father and are so addressed in the village. One woman told me they are taught from an early age to remember their different names, giving the example of the phrase she and her siblings were told to repeat if they sneezed: '*Kubala kwa amwale, kumtundu wankhoma*' – that is, born from '*amwale*', their father's clan, and belonging to the matrilineage of '*ankhoma*', their mother's group. Siblings of either sex, then, use the (gender-specific) names associated with the correct clan. But in the next generation, their children have different clan names since they take those of their fathers. The same woman explained to me that her brother's children would have the *mfunda* of his matriclan, hence '*ankhoma*'. As noted, marriages are often very short (a typical situation among matrilineal peoples), but children often maintain relations with their fathers throughout their life even though they may live with several of their mothers' husbands. The variation seems to owe as much to personalities and circumstances as to the degree of support any father may give his child (and vice versa). While people refer back several generations to their matrilineal forebears, the ties with a father's family rarely last beyond the one generation (as seen above in the oral histories).

Land, Work and Family

Today, as in the past, the livelihood of the majority depends on land. The research area is in the densely populated southern region (with densities of over 130 persons/km) where people produce maize and other food crops for sale and food, as well as tobacco, chili peppers and sunflowers. Since the villages are in the orbit of two urban centres, the production of vegetables for sale is also key to people's strategies. All these activities depend on gaining access to land and its resources. Although most of the land is legally under 'customary tenure', the absence of any uncultivated 'bush' in the area effectively means that fields are family property. They are passed down through the matriline and virtually all are passed to female heirs. A young girl helps work the fields of her mother or grandmother (or another matrilineal relative if she does not live with mother or grandmother), but receives her own field when she marries or, more usually, has her first child. As time goes on, she will receive other fields as elder matrilineal kin become too frail to work them or when they die. The few cases where married sons are given fields to work are those where there is no

daughter to inherit or where the family has a great deal of land. In a significant number of the few cases of sons using land in the research villages, serious disputes have broken out between them and the sisters or the sisters' daughters because the stated and practised norm is that daughters have priority over land: people say simply, 'sons leave'. For example, one such brother left after much bitter dispute with his sisters to take up residence in his wife's village; another man who remained attributed the lameness in his legs to sisters' sorcery; another was accused behind his back of having employed sorcery to kill the sister whose land he was then using.

The work of cultivating the fields is done by the woman, her husband and children. Often they raise a small amount of cash to hire young men or boys to clear and ridge the fields prior to planting which is done by the woman, husband and children; they may also be helped by one or a few casual workers with the weeding. Often these casual workers, especially for clearing and weeding, are relatives – the older children of sisters and other matrikin resident nearby – or unrelated neighbours. The better-off households, especially those that grow tobacco, hire a worker or two for the season, from clearing through to harvesting. These are rarely kin or neighbours but usually young men coming from poorer and more densely populated neighbouring districts. Those who grow tobacco on any scale also hire temporary workers (most of them neighbours and relatives) for harvesting the tobacco and sewing the bundles of leaves for hanging to dry.

As far as working the fields goes, then, the unit of production and management is the elementary family – woman, children, husband – usually referred to today as *banja*.¹⁰ The kin-based work-groups of other regions in Africa are absent here.¹¹ Despite living in close proximity to and sharing the family land with sisters and other matrikin, most of the time most women work alone with their children and husband. Occasionally, at harvest, one sees sisters working together, and sisters and other close kin will help one of their group who falls sick. Much the same holds for other income-earning activities. Sisters who brew beer or *kachasu* (local gin) do so each on her own though they usually coordinate and take turns in brewing in order to avoid an over-supply in relation to expected consumers; likewise for buying and selling crops, processing and selling foods (flour, cakes, cooked vegetables and meats). Each woman's husband is responsible for her and her children, although the mother of a man's wife is due great respect (and avoidance of any familiarity in demeanour or tone), and both she and the wife's sisters may expect to receive help with 'male' work (such as building granaries or thatching), and occasional gifts.

In much of daily life, the conjugal unit (*banja*) of a woman and husband with or without children appears to be the main unit of production and income-earning. Others working in the Shire Highlands have noted the 'individuated' patterns of work among sisters (Davison, 1993; cf. Vaughan, 1983). In terms of daily consumption, too, the distinction between sisters is

clear. Each woman with a husband has her own fire and cooks alone although the cooked food is often shared across the component households (*banja*). However, it would be a mistake to conflate the *banja* with the patriarchal household promoted by missionaries and agricultural officers described above. A conjugal unit in the research villages is embedded in the wife's matrilineal matrix of relationships. For example, when a husband is away (temporarily or for long periods) or when a woman divorces her husband or is widowed, a woman often gives up her own fire to take turns with sisters or mother to cook. It is well-recognized in the villages that a wife makes more effort cooking separately if a husband is around than not (this may have contributed to the male assessment of women becoming 'lazy' in men's absence recorded as fact by Margaret Read and discussed in Brantley's article, this issue).

Moreover, although the production and income strategies of the conjugal unit appear highly individuated, they in fact depend on access to resources, particularly land, through membership of a group of people sharing matrilineal descent. Hence, it would be wrong to assume that the contradiction between individualized production and distributive communalism, described for Luapula (Poewe, 1981), is typical of the matrilineal peoples of Malawi. On the contrary, such a formulation would obscure the dependence of conjugal units on matrilineal kin in the research villages. The more widely recognized sharing in consumption of food and other goods among matrikin (e.g. Vaughan, 1983, 1987) stands less in contrast to individuated production as being a more overt expression of the matrilineal relationships and transfers that make the household production possible.¹²

Against these realities of village life, it is important to remember that, for over a century, the male-headed (patriarchal) household has been promoted directly and indirectly by Islamic groups, Christian missions, government, and other European agencies mentioned earlier. After independence, agricultural extension and other services continued to be directed to male farmers and to assume a male-headed household as normal (Spring, 1995). Attempts over the past decade or so to 'target' women have done little to shift the underlying assumptions. Moreover, the small but influential elite in Malawi (educated people in the government, civil service, universities, professions) has taken on the shape and trappings of the bourgeois family, even though it appears that, in practice, spouses from matrilineal groups maintain many of the patterns of flows and interactions with their respective matrikin.¹³ Finally, the consistent favouring of men in the domains of education and employment has meant that they have much more secure access to new income and other opportunities. It is no surprise, then, that there is considerable competition among women for husbands and that there is a definite correlation between relative wealth and length of marriage in the villages. All these circumstances increase the

social and economic salience of the conjugal unit. Nevertheless, as I argue above, for the vast majority of people the conjugal unit's performance cannot be understood without close attention to its embeddedness in matrilineal matrices.

A final point has to join the strategies of matrilineal inheritance with conjugal unions. I have said that land is crucial to most people's lives and that it is in short supply (relative to people needing it). Most splitting of matrilineal groups is fuelled by disputes over land. Families I have been watching for ten years appear to be prone to intensifying disputes between sisters over land as their daughters mature and need fields. Family histories I have collected suggest that, in each generation, some sisters leave the villages (some moving to an area further north where there is still unused land to be requested from chiefs, some to the towns).

I stress relations around land because I believe these are crucial to understanding the way in which matrilineally related kin interact. Tension and disputes among siblings (brothers and sisters and among sisters) focus on land. When Mitchell carried out research among the Machinga Yao in the 1940s (in an area to the north of that I describe), he discussed how rivalry between groups of siblings over the headmanship was at the heart of the political dynamics of the villages (1956). A disappointed aspirant to the headmanship was likely to move off with a group of sisters to create his/their own village. That dynamic has long been impossible – there is no 'frontier' for creating new villages. The rivalries over existing chiefly positions do still entail rivalry and factioning between sibling groups. But for the rest of the population, rivalry focuses on land.

Although serious disputes occur between full sisters, often resulting in the departure of some, the sisters usually still consider themselves to be one group. The process of division (fissioning in the older vocabulary) of matrilineal groups is complex but appears to occur between sisters' daughters. The metaphor used to describe formal separation is 'breaking away' (*kutha*, to break, which is also the metaphor for divorce) from the larger matrilkin. The smaller group's collective authority and common belonging is recognized through ritual markers of separation from the larger set of matrilkin. One of these markers is who shares the same 'medicine', the potions or materials ritually applied by a specialist, administered at funerals or when someone returns from a long absence in foreign parts.

The tension and competition among siblings has not meant, however, the demise or even an obvious 'weakening' of matriliney. If there has been a victim of increasing land pressure (in the context of stagnant or declining income), it is not matriliney but the size of 'effective' matrilineal groups, and a narrowing in the scale of collaborative relations among matrilkin. This latter feature resembles trends described by many others for Africa – socio-economic differentiation entailing a narrowing in scale of social relations (e.g. Holy, 1986; Saul, 1992, among others; see Introduction, this volume).

This narrowing, in combination with the ideological promotion of a male-headed, nuclear household and the privileges extended to men, may also serve to reinforce the conjugal unit. In the villages, all the most successful families engaging in commercial farming and/or business are based on a strong partnership between husband and wife. Nevertheless, all of them continue to follow matrilineal descent and inheritance,¹⁴ and most, except for those who are traders with houses in the village market centres, live uxori-locally. Moreover, my earlier point that the 'household' as conjugal unit has to be seen as dependent on the encompassing network of matrikin is true for all, but especially for the majority of families who have very few resources (land or other wealth). For these, the need to spread resources in the face of pervasive uncertainty in economic and political life is paramount. To that extent, trends found more broadly in contemporary Africa (Berry, 1985; Poewe, 1981) are not absent in this land-pressured corner of Malawi but serve, in practice, to reinforce matriliney as a mode of organization and representation.

Notes

- 1 The fieldwork took place for a year during 1986–7 and a second year 1990–1, as well as shorter visits most years since then. Fieldwork and analysis have been supported by research grants from USAID and the World Bank, and by Harvard University. None of these organizations is responsible for my interpretations.
- 2 I should emphasize that I believe the description for the Zomba villages discussed holds for much of the Shire Highlands. However, while most of the people in other parts of the southern region (outside the Lower Shire) and central region follow matrilineal descent and inheritance, there is greater variation in (i) whether sons receive land and (ii) residence after marriage. Unfortunately, there is a dearth of research on these basic issues.
- 3 This section draws on an unpublished paper 'Matriliney Revisited: Land and Gender in Southern Malawi', presented to the African Studies Association Annual Meeting, Toronto, November 1994, and a manuscript ('Debating Commercialization in Malawi') in progress.
- 4 This debate is seen in the archival documents (annual reports of the Provincial Commissioner for the Southern Province, of district officers for Zomba and Chiradzulu, and reports on Land Tenure, and Africans on Private Estates). I have not come across any reference to sons marrying out; since this is likely to have occurred, I assume (for now) that some of these sons sought to marry women living on the estates and that the argument put forward by estate owners about 'surplus' populations emphasized the incoming sons-in-law rather than any outgoing sons.
- 5 In five out of nine villages, chiefs have chronic (ongoing) disputes with families who are descendants of his predecessors ('patrilineal segments'). There is no space to discuss this here.
- 6 This section draws on two unpublished papers, 'Balancing Cash and Food? Colonial Agricultural Policy and African Farming in Nyasaland (Malawi)', presented to the African Studies Association Annual Meeting, December 1993; and 'Transforming Land Rights: State Policy and Local Practice in a Matrilineal

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- Society', presented to Program in Agrarian Studies, Yale University, February 1993; and a manuscript ('Debating Commercialization in Malawi') in progress.
- 7 The reports on which the following paragraphs are based are found in MNA (Malawi National Archives) file NS 1/15/4.
 - 8 As described earlier, this region has been the scene of complex movements of people. The original inhabitants were Nyanja and Mang'anja; later came Yao and a large influx of Lomwe-speaking groups from Portuguese East Africa. These all share basically similar social and cultural characteristics (matrilineal descent and inheritance, uxorilocal residence, as well as key ritual and cosmological beliefs and practices, cf. Mitchell, 1951: 297). The predominant population in the research villages are of Lomwe and Nyanja origins, though those following Islam tend to be 'Yaoized' to an extent. People today will define their forebears, if asked, but most say 'we are all mixed up, now' and all speak Chichewa as their everyday language. For this reason, I do not refer to them with a 'tribal' or 'ethnic' designation; they seem to me to be a regional population.
 - 9 On divorce, the husband leaves his wife and children in her village and returns to his natal village. On the death of a woman, the widower must also leave his wife's village and the children almost always are taken by their matrilineal relatives, usually the sisters of the deceased woman whom the children, of course, already refer to as '*mai*' (mother).
 - 10 While *banja* usually refers to the elementary family based on a conjugal tie, the group it refers to may well contain other co-resident relatives, especially matrilin of the wife. At other times, too, *banja* is used to refer more generally to one's close family (beyond the elementary family) in much the way 'family' is used in English.
 - 11 Although older people say that there were reciprocal work groups in the past, the experience of the estates seems to have quickly quashed them. The 1938 Nutrition Survey villages further north (near present-day Nkhotakota) had extensive work parties fuelled by beer, which constituted a very high proportion of adult caloric intake at certain periods (Berry and Petty, 1992).
 - 12 These ideas about 'production' and 'consumption' are fleshed out theoretically and ethnographically in a paper 'Producing Wealth, Consuming Poverty (and Vice Versa) through Agricultural Commercialization in Malawi', I presented to the Program in Agrarian Studies, Yale University, March 1996.
 - 13 This statement is based on my own very casual observations of friends and acquaintances. The kind of research done for a Ghanaian 'matrilineal elite' by Christine Oppong (1981) is lacking in Malawi.
 - 14 Even the tiny minority of families with leasehold land (who are therefore legally distinguished from 'smallholders' who farm on 'customary' land) appear to operate as matrilineal units. I have no space to discuss this here.

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